

DRAMA



DRAMA HAS BEEN DELIGHTING people for at least 2,500 years. A Broadway musical, a play by Shakespeare, and a television soap opera are all different sorts of drama. What

they have in common is the presence of actors, who perform a story (the play) in a theatrical setting, to entertain an audience and make them think. Dramatists (writers of drama) use their art to entertain and thrill their audience or, more seriously, to explore human character and raise questions about the nature and meaning of life.

Renaissance and 17th century

The traditions of ancient Greek drama were revived in Renaissance Italy and spread through Europe. Many plays were written in verse. Drama thrived in the 16th and 17th centuries, the age of English playwright William Shakespeare (1564–1616) and his contemporaries.



Lope de Vega



Phèdre (1677), by Racine

France

The French dramatist Jean Racine (1639–99) wrote plays that were heavily influenced by Greek tragedy and often based on Greek mythology. Unusually for the time, many featured women in the title role. Another great dramatist of the era, Molière (1622–73), developed French comedy with plays that mocked the middle classes.

Spain

The 17th century was the Golden Age of Spanish theatre. The Spanish dramatist Lope de Vega (1562–1635) wrote some 1,500 plays; his play *Fuenteovejuna* was one of the first to deal with ordinary working people. The other great Spanish dramatist of this time was Pedro Calderón de la Barca (1600–81), who produced many tragedies and historical plays.

Types of drama

The many types of drama include tragedies (serious plays that deal with the downfall of a flawed but heroic individual) and light-hearted comedies (plays with happy endings). Other types include historical plays, thrillers, and musical theatre.

Waiting for Godot

(1955), by Irish writer Samuel Beckett (1906–89), is a type of modern drama known as the "Theatre of the Absurd": the plot seems to lead nowhere, suggesting life has no point.



The stage is empty, except for a single tree.

The heroes wait for someone who does not arrive.



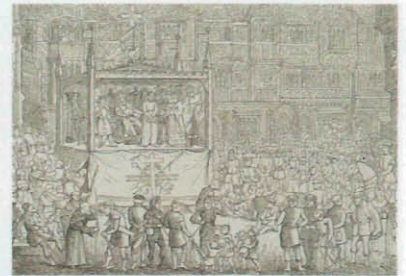
Early drama

Western drama originated in ancient Greece, where plays were staged to honour the gods. The Greeks invented two of the most enduring dramatic forms, tragedy and comedy, which were later imitated by the Romans.

Classical Greek drama

The ancient Greeks held regular drama festivals, at which dramatists competed for prizes. Their tragedies were based on characters from Greek mythology. Their comedies ranged in style from uproarious satires to more realistic dramas.

Statuette of muse, holding a mask from Greek comedy



Religious drama, York, England, 13th century

Medieval drama

Western drama went into a decline at the end of the Roman Empire, but revived in the 10th century, with the rise of Christian religious drama. Amateur players produced plays enacting stories from the Bible, performed over a number of days. The audience watched out of doors, in market-places and other public spaces.

Realism and 20th century

From the mid-18th century onwards, drama became increasingly realistic, with playwrights portraying middle-class characters in familiar situations. Theatres were fitted with picture-frame stages and realistic sets. It was fashionable for plays to deliver a direct, moral message. During the 20th century, dramatists experimented with dialogue and plot structure, in order to challenge "realism" or give dramas a symbolic meaning.

Mother Courage (1941), by Brecht, is set during the Thirty Years' War.



Realistic drama

Dramatists such as Norwegian Henrik Ibsen (1828–1906) and Swede August Strindberg (1849–1912) produced plays that attacked the narrow social attitudes of their time and sometimes shocked audiences with their frankness.

A Doll's House (1879), by Ibsen

Bertolt Brecht

In his plays, the German writer Bertolt Brecht (1898–1956) put forward serious socialist messages. He constantly reminded his audience that they were watching a play, to make them think about the socialist ideas in his works, and look more closely at the world outside the theatre.

Broadway

A street in New York at the heart of the city's theatre-going district, Broadway is world famous, and synonymous with the commercial theatre in North America. Broadway productions need a big budget and guaranteed audiences, so more experimental plays often appear in theatres "off-Broadway" first, and transfer to a Broadway theatre if successful.

